



Indigenous political participation in Canada : moving beyond voting to understand a variety of political means and actions

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Acknowledgements

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Outline

1. Puzzle
2. Littérature review (very quick overview)
3. Research question
4. Theoretical framework
5. Hypothesis (a lot → 9)
6. Data and Methodology
- 7. Results**
- 8. Discussion**
9. Conclusion

Puzzle

- The **bulk** of indigenous political participation literature in Canada has been focused on its **electoral** component.
 - Accessibility of data at the polling station level for *on-reserve* people only.
- We know little about other political acts in a **quantitative way** and at an **individual level**.
 - Scarcity of indigenous respondents in general population surveys.
- **Furthermore**, rare are the studies that compare indigenous political participation across types of participation from one dataset : **it's scattered**.
- What we need : **current state** of political participation.

Literature review

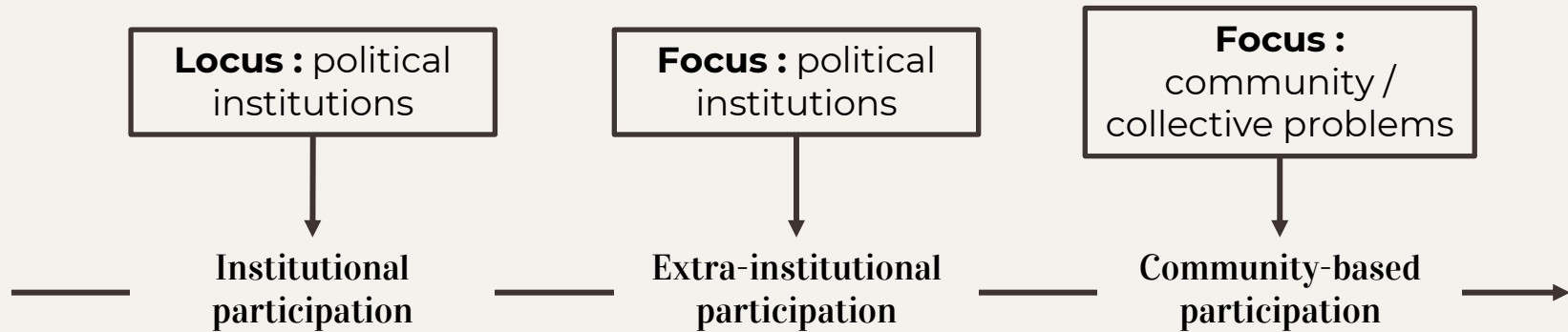
- Indigenous people in Canada vote at lower rates than non-indigenous Canadians.
(Beatty et coll., 2013; Harell et Panagos, 2013; Howe et Bedford, 2009; Dabin et coll., 2019).
- The frequency of Indigenous direct acts is constantly rising since the 1960's.
(Do, 2023; Ramos, 2006; Wilkes, 2004).
- Indigenous people tend to participate more within identity and cultural related organisation than they do in other types of organisation.
(Estes et coll., 2023; Harell, 2013;).
- Many researchers have hinted the **utmost importance** of **ressources** (*see the lack thereof*) to explain indigenous **electoral** participation.
- **However**, as we move out from institutionnal acts of participation, **ressources** tend to discriminate less and less the participants from the non-participants.

What are the explanations for the diverse forms of Indigenous political participation in Canada?

Research question

Theoretical framework

- Individual factors of political participation from the **civic voluntarism model**.
(Verba et coll., 1995).
- A conceptual definition of political participation (conceptual distance of political acts from formal institutions).
(Van Deth, 2014).



Hypothesis

- Descriptive hypothesis to test the association between **institutional distance** and the **type of participation**.

H1 : the **further** the political act is happening from the political institution, more the level of participation is **high**.

Hypothesis

- Two hypothesis to test the contribution of a **ressource-based** explication and a **psychological engagement-based** explanation of political participation.

H2a : ressources have a **larger** effect on **institutional** participation than on non-institutional participation.

H2b : psychological engagement has a **larger** effect on **non-institutional** participation than on institutional participation.

Hypothesis

- Three hypothesis to test the association between **issue engagement** (Verba et coll., 1995) and political participation.

H3a : Agreement that "a long history of colonial policies harms the social and economic well-being of Indigenous Peoples" is associated with **lower levels** of **institutional** participation among Indigenous people.

H3b : Agreement that "a long history of colonial policies harms the social and economic well-being of Indigenous Peoples" is associated with **higher levels** of **non-institutional** participation among Indigenous people.

H4 : Agreement that "Indigenous Peoples have received less than they deserve" is associated with **higher levels** of both **institutional** and **non-institutional** participation among Indigenous people.

Hypothesis (last ones)

- Three hypothesis to test specific factors of a **mobilisation-based** explanation.
(McClurg, 2003; Putnam, 2000; Verba et coll., 1995).

H5a : Greater ethnocultural diversity within one's social network is associated with **higher levels** of **institutional** participation.

H5b : Lower ethnocultural diversity within one's social network is associated with **higher levels** of **extra-institutional** participation.

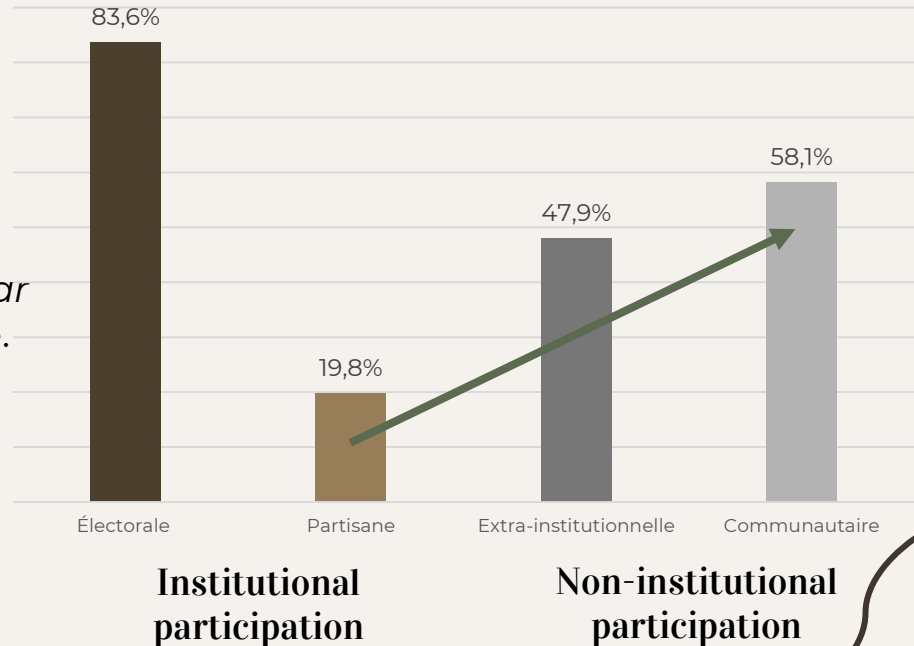
H6 : Both a **larger social network** and **higher frequency of political discussions** are associated with **higher levels** of both **institutional** and **non-institutional** participation.

Data and methodology

- *Democracy Checkups survey (2020 to 2024).*
- **Descriptive analysis** : measuring self-reported political participation of indigenous respondents (n = 1120).
 - 4 dependent variables : electoral, partisan, extra-institutional and community-based participation.
- **Block-recursive ordered logistic regression analysis** : to identify direction and strength of association between CVM independent variable and political participation (n = 1120, n = 810).
 - 2 dependent variables : institutional and non-institutional participation (each a 0-4 scale of reported political participation).
 - Metric : OR (SE)^{statistical significance}, beta coefficient.

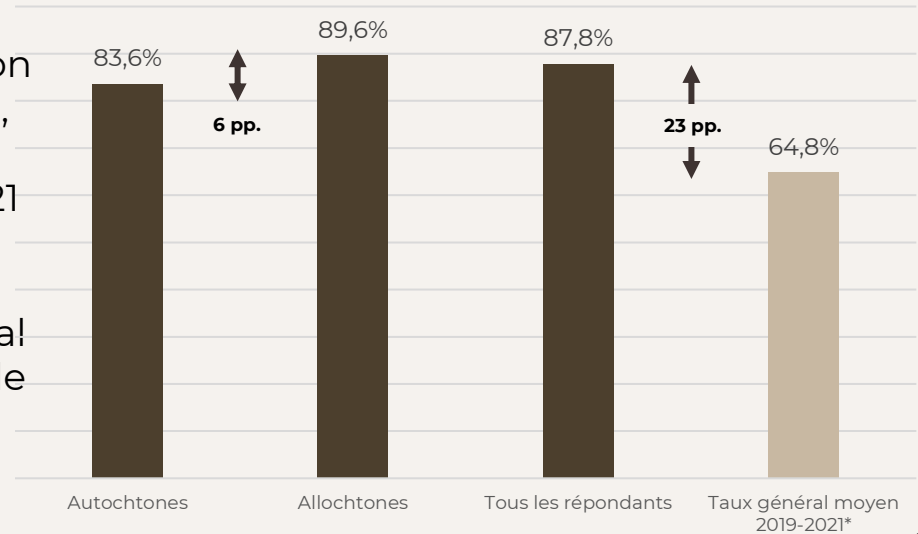
R1 – distance and participation

- Expected relation is partially respected.
- **Voting** remains the political act *par excellence* for Indigenous people.



R1 – in addition

- Self-reported electoral participation is **very high** for **ALL** respondents, and much higher than actual electoral participation in 2019-2021 federal elections.
- High self-reported level of electoral participation by Indigenous people **could reproduce** differences observed for all respondents.



R2a – explaining participation

- A **ressource-based** explanation of institutional participation **holds**, **BUT** couldn't be applied to non-institutional participation.

Variable	Institutionnelle	Non-institutionnelle
Âge	1.02 (0.00)*** 0.27	1.00 (0.00) -0.04
Éducation	1.35 (0.10)** 0.22	1.25 (0.10)* 0.16
Revenu	1.07 (0.07) 0.07	1.06 (0.07) 0.06

R2b – explaining participation

- **Psychological engagement** variable have a slightly larger effect on **institutional** participation.
- **However**, this explanation holds **central** to each type of political participation.

Variable	Institutionnelle	Non-institutionnelle
Intérêt politique	1.51 (0.11)*** 0.33	1.43 (0.10)*** 0.29
Efficacité politique interne	1.11 (0.08) 0.10	1.01 (0.08) 0.01
Efficacité politique externe	1.01 (0.08) 0.01	0.89 (0.07) -0.11
Force de l'identification partisane	1.50 (0.07)*** 0.42	1.16 (0.06)* 0.15

R3/4 – indigenous issue engagement

- Negative, small and non-significant associations.
- **1st limit** : survey questions ask for *agreement* rather than the *saliency of an issue* on the decision to participate.
- **2nd limit** : The module *Attitudes – Colonialism and Indigenous deserve* addresses *resentment* which may not fit conceptually here*.

Variable	Institutionnelle	Non-institutionnelle
Enjeux politiques coloniaux – historique	0.89 (0.12) -0.09	0.95 (0.11) -0.04
Enjeux politique coloniale – redistribution	0.94 (0.11) -0.05	0.97 (0.10) -0.02

*Thanks to Allison Harell for the precision brought to this matter last tuesday.

R5/6 – mobilization and social networks

- Moderate to strong positive association between **ethnocultural diversity** and **institutional** and **non-institutional** participation.
- La **valeur politique** du réseau social (fréquence des discussions politiques) est fortement associée aux deux types de participation politique.

Variable	Institutionnelle	Non-institutionnelle
Fréquence des discussions politiques	1.36 (0.10)** 0.26	1.37 (0.09)*** 0.27
Taille du réseau social	0.93 (0.10) -0.07	0.89 (0.09) -0.10
Diversité du réseau social	1.17 (0.09)† 0.15	1.56 (0.08)*** 0.43

R5/6 – mobilization and social networks

- The intensity of **social interactions** (as measured by social network size) is negative, weak and non-significant.
- **Limit :** Community group type isn't specified. **Could** influence the relation between *size of social networks* and *non-institutional* participation.

Variable	Institutionnelle	Non-institutionnelle
Fréquence des discussions politiques	1.36 (0.10)** 0.26	1.37 (0.09)*** 0.27
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Summary of hypothesis

	Expected association	Results	Support
H1	further = higher participation	Vote = most, but rest suits expectation	Not supported*
H2a	Ressources effect bigger on institutional	Age and education ++, income =	Supported
H2b	Psychological engagement effect bigger on non-institutional	Political interest and strenght of partisan indentity ++ for institutional.	Not supported

Summary of hypothesis

	Expected association	Results	Support
H3a	Agreement = lower institutional participation	Negative, small and non-significative	Supported*
H3b	Agreement = higher non-institutional participation	Negative, small and non-significative	Not supported
H4	Agreement = higher participation	Negative, small and non-significative	Not supported

Summary of hypothesis

	Expected association	Results	Support
H5a	More diversity = institutionnal participation higher	Positive, moderate and significant	Supported
H5b	Less diversity = non-institutional participation higher	Positive, strong and significant	Not supported
H6	Bigger social network More frequent political discussions = participation higher	Frequency = strong, positive and significant, Taille réseau = negative, small and not significant	Not supported

Discussion – theoretical framework

- **Possible mismatch** between institutional **distance** and **resource demands** across participation types.
- Each dependent variable includes types that are constraining in terms of time, money, or relatively less constraining.
- This could attenuate differences in participation levels and/or associations with explanatory factors.

Discussion – data

- **Broadening** the definition of political participation to account for Indigenous realities by including community-based participation type.

(Corntassel, 2012; Coulthard, 2014; Estes et coll., 2023).

- **However**, do these types of community-based participation align with Indigenous understandings of participation ?
 - Formal organisations, structured participation vs. informal community-based participation (Estes et coll., 2023) ;
 - Little room for **decolonial/Indigenous conceptualizations** of participation (Greaves, 2023).

Conclusion

Reminder : What are the explanations for the diverse forms of Indigenous political participation in Canada ?

- **Psychological engagement** emerges as the **central** explanation of both institutional and non-institutional political participation.

Variable	Institutionnelle	Non-institutionnelle
RESSOURCES		
Âge	1.02 (0.00)*** 0.27	1.00 (0.00) -0.04
Éducation	1.35 (0.10)** 0.22	1.25 (0.10)* 0.16
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ENGAGEMENT PSYCHOLOGIQUE		
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MOBILISATION		
Fréquence des discussions politiques	1.36 (0.10)** 0.26	1.37 (0.09)*** 0.27
Taille du réseau social	0.93 (0.10) -0.07	0.89 (0.09) -0.10
Diversité du réseau social	1.17 (0.09)† 0.15	1.56 (0.08)*** 0.43
Pseudo-R ² McFadden	0.091	0.055
N	811	810

Conclusion

- **IN CONTRAST**, a **resource-based** explanation for institutional participation **cannot be applied** to the same extent to **non-institutional** participation.
- **Mobilization** dynamics replace **resource constraints**.

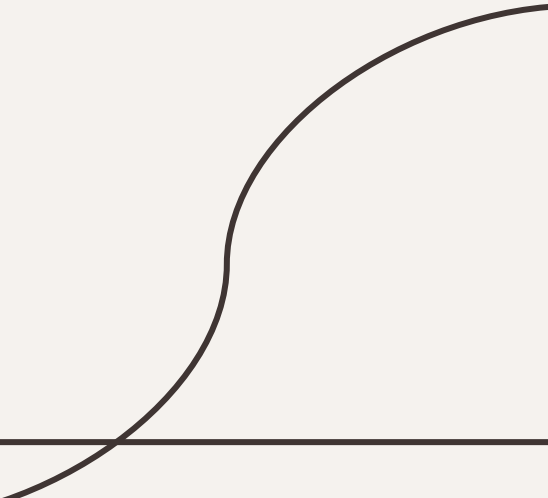
Variable	Institutionnelle	Non-institutionnelle
RESSOURCES		
Âge	1.02 (0.00)*** 0.27	1.00 (0.00) -0.04
Éducation	1.35 (0.10)** 0.22	1.25 (0.10)* 0.16
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MOBILISATION		
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Pseudo-R ² McFadden	0.091	0.055
N	811	810

Dans un mémoire près de chez vous...

(Also studied in this master's thesis)

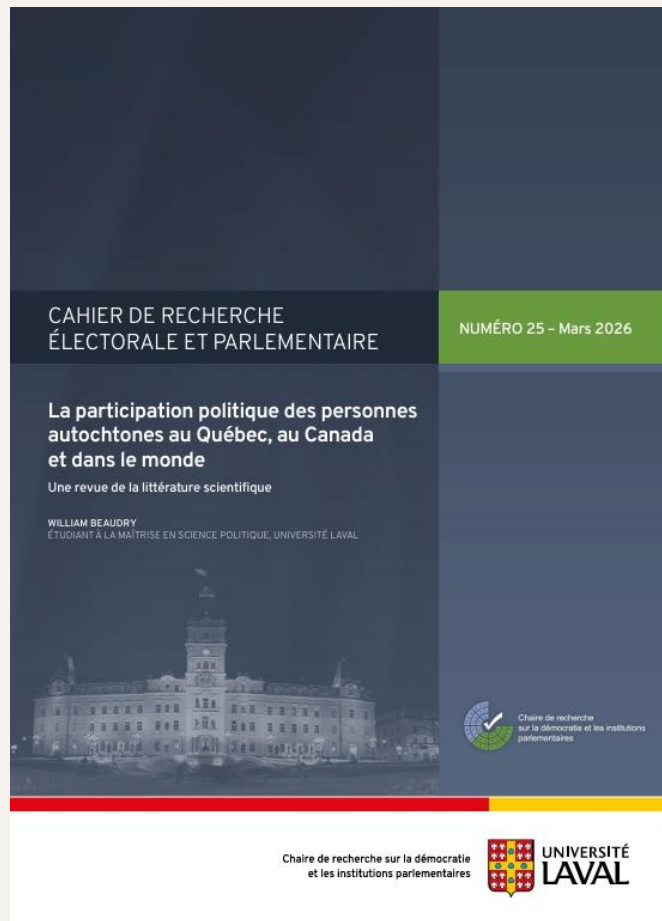
- My second question research goes as follow :

How do the explanations for the diverse forms of political participation compare between Indigenous and non-Indigenous peoples ?

- If you have questions about comparisons Indigenous/non-indigenous, feel free to ask !
- 

To get a good (in my honest opinion) overview of the literature →

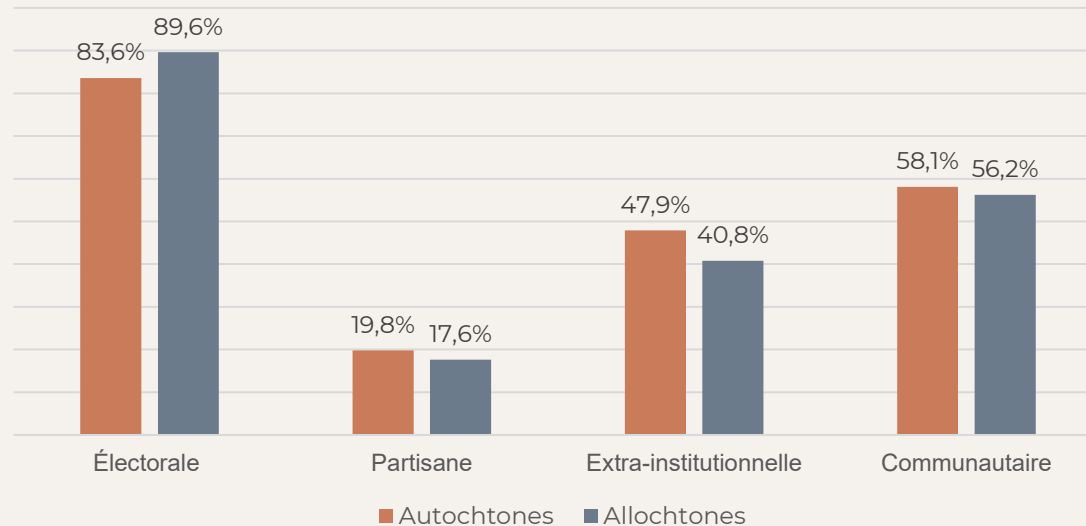
*Thanks to Juliettes Samson,
Ann-Sophie Gravel and, of course,
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support into the making of this.*



Thank you for
listening !

Appendix :

Comparison of political participation levels between Indigenous and non-indigenous Canadians (*Democracy Checkups, 2020-2024*)



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